

Attachments & Embedded Malware



Attachments ...

Phishing emails often include attachments that look harmless—but behind the scenes, they can unleash powerful malware.



Once opened they can ...

- Install spyware or keyloggers
- Encrypt your files (ransomware)
- Give remote control to an attacker
- Steal passwords, screenshots, or webcam feeds



Common File Types Used in Malicious Attachments

File Type	Risk Level	Why It's Dangerous
.exe	Very High	Directly installs programs (often malware)
.zip / .rar	High	Used to hide malicious files from detection
.doc / .docx	High	Can contain macros that execute code
.pdf	Medium to High	Can exploit reader vulnerabilities
.xls / .xlsx	High	Macro-enabled spreadsheets are a big risk
.html	Medium	Opens phishing sites directly in browser

⚠ Tip: Even if a file ends in .pdf, don't assume it's safe. Attackers can exploit vulnerabilities in PDF readers or use social engineering inside the document.



How Attackers Trick You

- Fake invoices or receipts
 - “Invoice_8723.pdf” from a vendor you’ve never heard of
- Job offers or resumes
 - “Resume – John Smith.docx” sent to HR staff
- Security alerts or package tracking slips
 - “FedEx_Label.zip” with malware inside
- Shared cloud files
 - Links that lead to fake Dropbox, Google Drive, or OneDrive pages





How to Stay Safe:

- Don't open attachments from unknown or unexpected sources—even if the name looks familiar.
- Verify with the sender using another method (e.g., phone or separate email).
- Watch out for pressure tactics ("Urgent!", "Final Notice!").





How to Stay Safe:

- Disable macros by default in Microsoft Office.
- Keep software and antivirus updated—this can block known threats.
- Use email protection tools that scan attachments before download.



Key Takeaway

If you weren't expecting it, don't open it. Attachments can be the Trojan horse of phishing—simple on the outside, dangerous on the inside.

